

a full-fledged test we conducted on several anti-virus solutions, both free and paid.

3.2.1 How We Tested

All the anti-virus solutions were tested individually on a fresh installation of Windows XP Professional SP2. The test machine comprised an Intel Pentium 4 3.2 GHz processor with 1 GB DDR2 RAM and a Maxtor 120 GB 7200 RPM SATA hard drive. We installed the latest updates for Windows XP and the latest drivers for hardware, as well as DirectX 9.0c.

We noted the initial boot-up time of the test machine and the increase in boot-up time after the anti-virus software was installed. We restarted Windows twice to make sure that all the services installed by the anti-virus were up and running. We thoroughly scanned the entire hard drive and noted the time taken to complete the scan process. We noted the page file usage of the clean system and then noted the memory usage after the anti-virus was installed, then once again during the test scan. The average CPU usage during the test scan was also noted.

We obtained the virus scanning scores of individual anti-virus software from www.av-test.org and compared the test results head-to-head. Since the virus detection rate was almost 100 per cent for these solutions, we compared the average response time of the companies in case of virus outbreaks.

The response time to a virus outbreak is of prime importance because it determines the time period for which the computer remains vulnerable to attacks from a new virus. It is the average time taken for the anti-virus to receive the update required to protect your computer against the new virus.

In addition to performance, we also noted and rated various important features. We noted the number of clicks it takes to initiate a virus scan. We also noted whether features such as heuristic scan, e-mail scan, rescue disk creation, installation size